

Justin Simpson

Lecturer II · Department of Philosophy, University of Texas Rio Grande Valley

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AREAS OF SPECIALIZATION

Environmental Ethics, Social Epistemology, Material Feminisms / New Materialisms, Science and Technology Studies

AREAS OF COMPETENCE

Ethics of Technology, Bioethics, Indigenous Philosophies, Ethics, Food Ethics, and Logic

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

University of Texas Rio Grande Valley (UTRGV), Lecturer, August 2022–present

EDUCATION

Ph.D. Philosophy, University of Georgia (UGA), May 2022

Dissertation: *Posthuman Performances in Environmental Ethics and Social Epistemology*. Committee: Chris Cuomo (chair), Piers Stephens, Sarah Wright, Ronald Bogue

M.A. Philosophy, University of North Florida (UNF), 2015

Thesis: *Quasi-Subjectivity and Ethics in Non-Modernity*. Committee: Erinn Gilson (chair), Bryan Bannon, Hans-Herbert Koegler

B.S. Philosophy, Magna Cum Laude, University of North Florida, 2012

B.S. Physics and Mathematics, Magna Cum Laude, University of North Florida, 2011

BOOK

Toward an Environmental Ethic of Surprise: Adventures in Attention, December 2025

CHAPTERS IN EDITED COLLECTIONS

“A Tale of Two Rices: An Ethical Comparison of Golden Rice and Carolina Gold Rice Through a Performative New Materialist’s Lens,” in *Embodying Biodiversity: Sensory Conservation as Refuge and Sovereignty*, The University of Arizona Press, Spring 2024. ISBN: 9780816553983

ARTICLES

“Moving Forward by Going Back: An Environmental Ethic of Flower and Song in Aztec Philosophy,” *Public Philosophy Journal* 7(1). doi.org/10.59522/JVRR4931

“A Posthumanist Social Epistemology: On the Possibility of Nonhuman Epistemic Injustice,” *Anthropos: Journal of Psychology & Philosophy* 55(2), Fall 2023, special issue “Animals (Dis)Entangled or towards ‘A New Form of Civilization.’” doi.org/10.26493/2630-4082.55.195-213

“Towards a Joyful Environmental Ethic: Open-ended Curiosity as an Environmental Virtue,” *Journal of Ethnobiology* 43(3), Fall 2023. doi.org/10.1177/02780771231194777

“Eventful Conversations and the Positive Virtues of a Listener” (co-authored with Josué Piñeiro), *Acta Analytica*, 2020, 35. doi.org/10.1007/s12136-020-00429-x

“The Significance of Contingency and Detour in Hans Blumenberg’s Philosophical Anthropology,” *Metaphilosophy*, 2020, 50(1), 111–127. doi.org/10.1111/meta.12399

CONFERENCE PROCEEDINGS

“The Potential and Limitations of Aristotelian Final Causes in the Life Sciences,” a commentary on Lane DesAutels’ “Vindicating Metaethical Naturalism: A Case for Final Causes in the Life Sciences,” *Southwest Philosophy Review: The Journal of the Southwestern Philosophical Society*, 39(2), July 2023. doi.org/10.5840/swphilreview202339245

PENDING / FORTHCOMING

“A Weird and Eerie Analysis of Electrical Cords and Wires,” accepted to the edited collection *Finding Our Place In the Digital World*, under contract with Springer

BOOK REVIEWS

The Abyss Stares Back: Encounters with Deep-Sea Life by Stacy Alaimo, forthcoming in *Environmental Values*

How to Inhabit the Earth: Interviews with Nicolas Truong (with Bruno Latour), *Environmental Values*, 34(1), 109–111, 2024. doi.org/10.1177/09632719241273551

On the Emergence of an Ecological Class: A Memo by Bruno Latour and Nikolaj Schultz, *Environmental Values*, 33(5), 571–573, 2023. doi.org/10.1177/09632719231196541

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

“One Person’s Trash is Another’s Treasure: An Aesthetic Environmental Ethic of Wasting Fully,” International Association of Environmental Philosophy, May 2026

“The Death of Logos and Thumos in the Digital Worlds of Social Media and Generative AI” (co-authored with Amin Amouhadi), Digital Worlds Workshop, April 2026

“From Confederate monuments to digital worlds: on the epistemic vices and virtues of material-discursive atmospheres,” Bled Philosophical Conference, June 2025

“An Environmental Ethic of Love: On Human-Plant Liberations,” 29th annual meeting of the International Association for Environmental Philosophy (IAEP), May 2025

“An Aztec Analysis of Plato’s Symposium,” panel on “Encounters with Nature in Ancient Philosophy,” CAMWS conference, March 2025

“A Weird and Eerie Analysis of Electrical Cords and Wires,” Finding Our Place in the Digital World Workshop, February–March 2025

“Moving Forward by Going Back: A Diffractive Analysis of Song and Flower in Aztec Philosophy,” Philosophy in the Wild conference, July 2024

“Academic Trauma and Healing,” East-West Philosopher’s Conference (Hawaii), May 2024

“Moving Forward by Going Back: An Environmental, Diffractive Analysis of Song and Flower in Aztec Philosophy,” 28th annual meeting of the IAEP, May 2024

“Environmental Philosophy and the Ethics of Attention,” webinar hosted by the ISEE and IAEP, April 2024

“Moving Forward by Returning to the Aztec Philosophy of Song and Flower,” New Mexico and Texas Philosophical Society, April 2024

“Light in the Dark: On Why and How I teach Gloria Anzaldúa in an Ethics, Technology, and Society Course,” North American Association for Philosophy and Education Conference, October 2023

“Towards a more-than-human social epistemology: on the possibility of nonhuman epistemic injustice,” Bled Philosophical Conference, June 2023

“Bio-temporal-diversity and becoming-through-death,” Colby Summer Institute in Environmental Humanities, August 2022

“Bio-temporal-diversity and becoming-through-death,” IAEP Spring Online Workshop, June 2022

“Reclaiming Our Future: Becoming-Through-Death and Gift Giving,” Southeastern Association for the Continental Tradition, April 2022

“On the Breakdown and Restoration of Trust between Science and the Public,” Roles of Governments and Societal Actors in Mitigating Climate Change Webinar (Illinois Institute of Technology), April 2022

“Towards a Positive, Joyful Environmental Ethic: Gratitude, Gift Giving, and Nonhuman Epistemic Justice,” IAEP 25th Annual Meeting, October 2021

“Episodic Memory, Material Culture, and Retrospective Epistemic Violence,” Eastern Division Meeting of the American Philosophical Association (APA), January 2021

“Episodic Memory, Material Culture, and Retrospective Epistemic Violence,” Georgia Philosophical Society Online Workshop, October 2020

“Against Anthropocentric Epistemologies and the Possibility of Nonhuman Testimonial Injustice,” IAEP 24th Annual Meeting, October 2020

“Personal Identity, Memory, and Material Culture,” 44th Annual Mid-South Philosophy Conference, March 2020 (cancelled, COVID-19)

“Engineering Consent with Ag-Gag Laws—Oh, the Humanity!” Association for Practical and Professional Ethics, Atlanta, February 2020

“Eventful Conversations and the Positive Virtues of a Good Listener,” Bled Philosophical Conference, Slovenia, June 2019

“From Farm to Table: A Tale of Two Rice and the ANTs in the Food,” Agriculture, Food, and Human Values Society, Madison, June 2018

JOURNAL ARTICLE REVIEWS

Acta Analytica (Spring 2026); *Environmental Values* (Spring 2025; Spring 2026)

CONFERENCE PAPER COMMENTARIES

“New Ways to be Unheard,” Digital Worlds Conference, April 2025

“The Will to Submit: Surveillance Technologies and Their Impact on Academia,” Digital Worlds Workshop, April 2023

“Vindicating Metaethical Naturalism: A Case for Final Causes in the Life Sciences,” Southwestern Philosophical Society, November 2022

AWARDS

Outstanding Commitment to Building Community Award, UGA Graduate School, Spring 2022

Dissertation Completion Award, UGA Franklin College of Arts and Sciences, Spring 2021 (\$21,840)

Joseph Bertram Gittler Fellowship, UGA Philosophy Department, 2021 (\$3,000)

Outstanding Teaching Assistant, UGA Center for Teaching and Learning, 2020–2021

IAEP Conference Best Graduate Student Paper Award, October 2020 (\$250)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Texas Rio Grande Valley

PHIL 4325: Philosophy of Capitalism and Economics, Spring 2026

PHIL 3301: Ancient Philosophy, Spring 2026

PHIL 4328: Environmental Philosophy, Fall 2025
PHIL 4310: Epistemology, Fall 2025
BIET 6316: Environmental Philosophy (online), Spring 2025
PHIL 2322: Ethics, Health, and Culture, Spring 2024 – Spring 2025
PHIL 4318: Philosophy of Food, Fall 2023
PHIL 3307: Indigenous Philosophy and Religion, Fall 2023
PHIL 2326: Ethics, Technology, and Society, Fall 2022 – Spring 2026 (incl. online)

University of Georgia (Instructor of Record)

PHIL 2030: Introduction to Ethics, 2018–2021 (incl. online)
PHIL 2010: Introduction to Philosophy, 2019–2021 (incl. online)
PHIL 2500: Symbolic Logic, Fall 2019, Spring 2020 (98 students; supervised a graduate TA)
PHIL 2020: Logic and Critical Thinking, Fall 2020 (84 students; supervised a graduate TA)
Teaching Assistant: PHIL 2010 (2016, A. Samaras); PHIL 2030 (2017, P. Stephens)

University of North Florida

Instructor of Record: Introduction to Philosophy, Fall 2015
Grading TA: Business Ethics, 2012–2013
Courses prepared to teach: Philosophy of Science; Modern Philosophy; 20th-Century Continental Philosophy; Feminist Philosophy; Ancient Philosophy

PROFESSIONAL & DEPARTMENTAL SERVICE

UTRGV

Chair of the Philosophy Pedagogy Group, Spring 2025–Spring 2026
Organizer, Philosophy for the People Symposium, Spring 2026
Organizer of Philosophy Film Nights, Fall 2025–Spring 2026
Search Committee for a three-year lecturer in Bioethics, Spring 2025
Outreach Committee (Fall 2022–present); Policy Committee (Fall 2022–present)
Co-organized the “Environmental Philosophy and the Ethics of Attention” ISEE/IAEP webinar, April 2024; participated in planning the 2022 Eco Rio conference

UGA

Chair, Racial Justice Committee, United Campus Workers of Georgia, Fall 2021 (co-led a living-wage campaign; co-authored op-eds and a resolution)
Chair / Co-chair, UGA chapter and Graduate Committee, United Campus Workers of Georgia, 2018–2021 (led a three-year campaign to eliminate the \$450 Special Institutional Fee)
Philosophy Graduate Representative, Graduate Student Association, Fall 2019–Spring 2021
Assistant Organizer, “Nature, Technology, and AI” workshop at UGA, Fall 2021
Vice President, Philosophy Graduate Student Association, Fall 2017–Fall 2019 (initiated the department’s first online courses)

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

UTRGV B3 Spanish Immersion Program: Beginning Spanish I & II, Intermediate Spanish II (2022–2024)
Summer Institute in Environmental Humanities, Colby College (Amrith, Chen, DeLoughrey, Yusoff), 2022; UGA Certificate in Diversity and Inclusion training, 2021–2022

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

American Philosophical Association (APA); International Association for Environmental Philosophy (IAEP); Association for Practical and Professional Ethics (APPE)

LANGUAGES

English (native); Spanish (learning, via UTRGV courses)

DISSERTATION SUMMARY

Existential crises such as climate change and the sixth mass extinction are not merely technical problems; they require rethinking humanity and our relation to the natural environment. Drawing on the material feminisms of Karen Barad, Donna Haraway, and Rosi Braidotti, the dissertation argues that nonhumans—from clay to COVID-19, amoebas to supercolliders—are active participants in the world’s becoming, co-constituting human bodies, experience, identity, and agency.

It stages three encounters between posthumanisms, environmental ethics, and social epistemology. First, it develops an environmental ethic for multispecies flourishing grounded in biocultural diversity, applied to two rices heralded as the future of food: the landrace Carolina Gold and the genetically modified Golden Rice. Second, it expands social epistemology to nonhuman animals, arguing that they can suffer testimonial injustice and epistemic smothering (after Fricker and Dotson), so that species extinction is the loss of entire worlds and ways of knowing.

Finally, drawing on Robin Wall Kimmerer’s account of gratitude, gift giving, and reciprocity—and on Vinciane Despret’s ethology—it presents an affirmative, joyful environmental ethic centered on the onto-epistemic virtue of openness: a way of doing good for the environment that can also feel good, and so be sustained.